

The First Few Minutes: When a Student Loses It

For the adult in the room right after a blow-up. Your response, the room, and the referral.

CLASSROOM MANAGEMENT

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

If anyone could get hurt, get another adult.

Restraint and seclusion are not de-escalation tools. Imminent danger only, trained staff only. [NASP 2021]

YOUR RESPONSE COMES FIRST

1 Lower your voice. Slow your movements.

Keep instructions few and clear. State plainly what behaviour you expect right now.

2 Hold the boundary without piling on.

Set a firm limit on the behaviour. Decide any consequence after things are calm, logically rather than punitively.

3 Give one safe choice.

Loss of control is often part of what the student is reacting to. Offer one real, small choice, where to sit or whether to stand by the door, instead of a string of instructions.

DO NOT ASSUME YOU KNOW THE REASON

Blowing up at correction can be a trauma reaction, not defiance.

That does not remove the boundary above. It should stop you deciding you know the cause before anyone trained has looked.

AFTER THE MOMENT, NOT DURING IT

4 Support, then refer.

Offer support yourself if you can, or refer the student to your counsellor or school mental health professional.

5 Give it a time and a place.

Set aside an actual time to talk about what happened, rather than processing it in front of the class.

WHEN TO ESCALATE

Severe, or happening repeatedly? Refer it.

You do not need to be certain what is behind it first. Let a school mental health professional make that call.

Suspect abuse? Follow your district reporting procedure.

Separately, and without waiting on anything above. Your district policy governs the procedure.

What is deliberately not here

Not on this card, on purpose: breathing exercises, calming scripts, or any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.

Sources: NCTSN Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators pp.4-6; NCTSN Psychological First Aid for Schools, Core Action 3; NASP 2021 on restraint and seclusion. Full citations in the guide.